

SECTION TWENTY - ONE

COMMON ROMANTASY WORLDBUILDING MISTAKES

Every genre has its pitfalls, and romantasy is no exception. Here are the most common worldbuilding mistakes made by romantasy authors, the patterns which cause readers to be irritated enough to either write negative reviews regarding “holes” in the plot, or set the book aside with a sense of disappointment.

Chances are, many of these are things you have seen before as a reader. This appendix will help you recognise when you're falling into them as a writer, and show you how to fix them.

They're grouped by type so you can jump to what's most relevant:

- **Getting the Balance Wrong** (Mistakes #1–3): Too much world, too little world, or world and romance that never actually meet.
- **Tone and Authenticity** (Mistake #4): When the world looks medieval but feels modern.
- **Stakes and Consistency** (Mistakes #5–7): When danger isn't dangerous, rules aren't rules, and tension takes convenient breaks.
- **Power and Agency** (Mistakes #8–9): When captivity or fate does the romance's job instead of the characters.
- **Pacing and Delivery** (Mistake #10): When worldbuilding arrives in a wall of text instead of woven through the story.

Getting the Balance Wrong

These mistakes are all about the relationship between your world and your romance. Too disconnected, too lopsided, or too perfectly engineered.



Mistake #1: The Backdrop World

The world exists, but it doesn't *do* anything. Characters are established as far as settings go, yet no setting ever has any impact on the plot. Magic exists but never creates problems. Politics are mentioned but never affect the characters. The romance could happen anywhere; this just happens to be a castle instead of a coffee shop. Think about the later ACOTAR books. The Night Court is supposed to be the largest, most diverse territory in Prythian, but the story stays almost entirely inside Velaris, this beautiful protected bubble where the Inner Circle can heal and bond without the wider world intruding. The Illyrian camps, the Hewn City, the political infrastructure: they're all out there somewhere, but they rarely press in on the characters in ways that shape the romance. Compare that to *House of Earth and Blood*, where Bryce and Hunt's relationship grows as a result of their investigation into the city's secrets and the power dynamics at play within the city. You can't separate their romance from the world because the world is what forces them together, keeps them in danger, and shapes the choices they make about each other. Usually because the writer built the world and the romance separately, then put them in the same book without integrating them. The world is *setting*, not *story*. Each time you build a significant piece of your world (magic, politics, culture) ask yourself two things: "How does this create obstacles for the romance?" and "How does this create opportunities for intimacy?" If you can't answer both, the element isn't integrated. Go back to your worldbuilding and add friction. Your magic system should create at least one major obstacle. Your political structure should forbid something the characters want to do. Your cultural customs should make their relationship taboo, dangerous, or complicated. The world should be actively making their lives difficult, and that difficulty should be specific to *this* world, not generic obstacles that could exist anywhere.



Mistake #2: Forgetting the Non-Romantic Story

There is a romantic plot line only and the fantasy plot line is just there to give the romantic plot line something to do between the romantic scenes. There's a villain, but they're barely developed. There's a quest, but it's just something to do while the couple are falling in love. The "fantasy" part of romantasy is thin, perfunctory, or obviously subordinate to the relationship. The *From Blood and Ash* series is a good cautionary example. In that series, the fantasy plot is becoming harder and harder to follow and summarise. The mythology shifts between books, the villain reveals repeat, and many fans of the series have said that the fantasy lore is really just used to create roadblocks to the couple's relationship instead of creating a cohesive fantasy world. Compare that with *The Cruel Prince*, where the political intrigue is the main event. Jude is trying to survive in a cruel world ruled by faeries and she's fighting for her right to rule too. Her fight for survival and her fight for power *are* the story, and her romance with Cardan develops from their mutual involvement in that struggle. By the end of the series, Jude and Cardan rule a kingdom together, and both the romantic arc and the political arc feel complete because the two are so closely tied together that you can't think of the story without thinking of both. The writer is primarily interested in the romance and uses the fantasy elements to fill in the background. They might not enjoy or feel comfortable writing action, politics, or magic. The romance is the story and everything else is just filler. If you want to make your fantasy conflict interesting enough to stand alone, you need to give your antagonist real motivations. Your antagonist needs to be able to cause real damage, your antagonist needs real power, and your antagonist needs to pose a real threat. And your protagonist needs to have goals that go beyond just getting together with the love interest. One of the key words to remember here is *integrate*, not subordinate. Don't subordinate the romance to the fantasy elements. Don't subordinate the fantasy elements to the romance. The romance and fantasy conflict lines should be so intertwined that you cannot see them separately. A good litmus test: would you still read this book if the romance was taken out of the story? If the answer is no, then your fantasy conflict line needs more development. You're writing romantasy. Both conflict lines need to carry the weight of the story.



Mistake #3: The One Perfect World

Every element of the worldbuilding exists solely for the sake of the romance. All customs create a sense of romantic tension. Every law forbids exactly what the characters want to do. Every magical element is about connection. The world feels engineered rather than lived-in. This is the opposite of Mistake #1. There, the world didn't affect the romance enough. Here, the world affects *only* the romance, and nothing else feels real. Basgiath Academy in *Fourth Wing* sometimes tips into this territory. The training programme is absurdly lethal, rebel children are placed near dragons despite obvious security risks, and the entire setup functions primarily to generate proximity and friction between Violet and Xaden. It seems as if the world was built simply to allow the romance to occur and not to provide a believable military academy where Violet and Xaden just happen to be attending. Now look at *House of Earth and Blood* again. Crescent City is full of characters with their own agendas, neighbourhoods with their own histories, and social dynamics that have nothing to do with Bryce and Hunt. The world has a life beyond the couple, and that's what makes it feel real. Taking the advice to make worldbuilding "serve the story" too literally. The writer builds only what's directly relevant and nothing else, creating a world that's thin and artificial. You should have secondary characters with their own interests. You should have historical events that are simply history. You should have cultural aspects that add to the overall texture of your world, but do not create a plot point. Not everything needs to be Chekhov's gun. The world doesn't care about your protagonists' romance. People are shopping at the marketplace whether they're in love or not. The war continues regardless of their feelings. Let the world feel like it exists independent of them. Other people are living their lives, other romances exist, other concerns matter. Your protagonists' story is *one* story, not *the* story.

Tone and Authenticity

This mistake is about the gap between how your world looks and how it actually feels to live in.



Mistake #4: Medieval Europe with Starbucks

The overall atmosphere appears to be pseudo-medieval fantasy (castles, horses, swords), yet every single character behaves, speaks, and thinks as if they were living in today's time. Modern American ideas about gender, class, and who you hang out with come into play in the story, while the social structures that would actually exist in this kind of society are either nonexistent, or can be brushed off when it gets inconvenient. *Fourth Wing* is most often used as an example for this. This is set in a medieval-inspired military academy where there are dragon riders, but the main characters talk to themselves internally and each other using modern slang and contemporary speaking styles that don't fit in with the brutal environment they live in. The danger is supposed to be institutional and psychological, but the narrative voice remains snarky and self-aware in ways that diminishes the seriousness of the setting. *A Court of Silver Flames* does a similar thing: modern terms used in the area of health and fitness and anatomical references appear in a pseudo-medieval world that supposedly existed before those things did. On the flip side, *The Cruel Prince* does a great job of handling this. Holly Black built Elfhame based on its own internal logic, and therefore the fae have their own cultural laws and rules, their own forms of cruelty, their own sense of what is normal, and Jude's human perspective provides a lot of real frustration in opposition to that culture instead of just ignoring it. Many authors are drawn to the look of a historical fantasy world, but none of the constraints. They want their protagonist to be free-thinking and to have equal status as their peers, which is much harder to write about in a historically-accurate world. Some authors simply may not realise the vastly different ways people thought and lived in pre-modern societies. There are several ways to approach this, and they are all legitimate. The first option is to make the historical world feel historical. Do your research. Write how pre-modern societies actually functioned. While your protagonist can still be unique, they will be unique *within the confines of the world*: pushing against real limitations, dealing with real consequences, finding ways to wield power within the limitations of the system. The second option is to build a world where modern values make sense. You don't have to write about the way people thought and acted in historical times! However, if your world has gender equality for instance, you need to explain why. What makes this society unique that allows for such differences in societal norms? Use the same worldbuilding techniques to create the modern attitudes *as you do to create the rest of your world* don't assume them to be true. The third option is to acknowledge the tension openly. Your protagonist can have anachronistically modern views, but make *that* the focal point. Illustrate that their attitudes are causing them to run counter to their society. Do not pretend that everyone else secretly believes in what they believe. This is significant because when social constraints are believable, forbidden love becomes truly *forbidden*. There is a difference between having the rules of the society *bend* for a couple when they need it to, versus having rules that are so consistently real, that a couple running counter to them puts them in real danger of being discovered. The excitement of the act of defiance, the danger of getting caught: all of that depends upon the world having real rules that can be broken by someone who cares enough to take the risk.

Stakes and Consistency

These mistakes all undermine tension in the same fundamental way: they teach readers not to believe what you've told them about your world.

Mistake #5: Political Danger That Pauses for Romance

The worldbuilding establishes high stakes (war, political intrigue, deadly consequences for rule-breaking) but these stakes mysteriously pause whenever the romance needs space. The approaching army waits. The dangerous court stops watching. The forbidden relationship proceeds without interruption because the plot needs them to have their moments. In *ACOWAR*, the war against Hybern is the stated central conflict, but major political events (kidnapping, forced participation in the Blood Rite, institutional violence) have almost no legal or political consequences. All of the major conflicts are ultimately reduced to minor subplots in service of the emotional development of the characters. The politics feel shallow because they bend around the romance instead of pressing into it. *The Cruel Prince* does this differently. Jude and Cardan's romance *is* the political story. Their attraction develops through shared navigation of a court that would destroy them both if they made a wrong move. The political danger never pauses because the romance lives inside it, and by the end of the series they're working as political partners. The romance feels earned precisely because it was never separated from the stakes. Writers want to give the romance room to breathe but don't know how to create space within the ongoing tension. They build high-stakes worlds and then can't figure out how to make the romance work *inside* those stakes. Rather than pausing the danger for romance, let the romance happen *during* the danger. Perhaps their first kiss occurred while they were hiding from enemies. Perhaps their confession happened before a battle they might not survive. Perhaps they grew closer because they're the only people each other can trust in hostile territory. If you need lower-tension scenes, build them into the worldbuilding. Safe houses that actually make sense. Travel time between locations. Recovery periods after battles. Make the "safe" moments feel earned and temporary. And even during romantic scenes, keep the reader reminded of the danger that awaits. A deadline they're aware of. The sound of armies marching in the distance. The knowledge that they'll have to return to the danger soon. Intimacy under pressure is more intense, not less.

Mistake #6: The Soft-Boiled World

The world has dangers, however those dangers do not ultimately harm anyone who is a significant part of the story. War exists within the world as the backdrop to our stories, however, no major characters die. There are relationships that are forbidden, however, no one ever faces consequences for being involved in a forbidden relationship. The risk is abstract versus concrete. The ACOTAR series struggles with this, particularly when characters are able to come back to life after their deaths. When a main character dies and is later resurrected through some form of magic that is easily available, it sends the message to the reader that the world doesn't really mean it when it threatens someone. The darkness we try to create is undermined by the fact that nothing is permanently going to happen to the people we care about. *Throne of Glass* offers a strong counterexample. The death of Nehemia in *Crown of Midnight* was a significant and permanent event that changed the entire series. Instead of being a mere adventure, the world became a place with true consequences for the protagonist. It changed the protagonist in a way that could not be reversed, and as such made each subsequent threat in the series seem more believable because the reader knew that this world means what it says. While it is difficult to harm characters that you love, and even more difficult when you fear that the consequences of doing so will interfere with the romantic development that you're building toward, readers can tell the difference between "dark atmosphere" and "actual stakes." You don't have to kill your protagonists. However, *something* negative should happen that is permanent. A secondary character could die. The forbidden relationship is found out and *there are* consequences for breaking the rules. The escape plan fails and the characters must deal with the consequences of being captured. If the only obstacles your characters face are temporary and can be easily overcome, the tension created is empty. Temporary setbacks are not a measure of stakes. For example, if a character is arrested, but is eventually released without any long-term effects, that is not a stake. Some losses should be permanent. So go ahead and hurt your protagonists. Make sure they fail sometimes at things that matter. Allow them to lose something they cannot replace. Allow the antagonist to win at least once. Struggling that leads to ultimate victory is uninteresting; struggling where the costs are real is interesting.



Mistake #7: Inconsistent World Rules

Rules about magic, politics, culture, geography that you've established don't stay consistent. Things that were established as true stop being true. Travel times change. Magic works differently in different scenes. Laws are enforced selectively. The world bends to accommodate whatever the current scene needs. The *Fourth Wing / Iron Flame* series has been picked apart by readers for timeline and travel inconsistencies. Flight times between locations don't add up against the graduation countdown, and characters seem to move at whatever speed the current scene requires. *From Blood and Ash* has a related problem where the mythology and power system shift significantly between books, with abilities and lore established in one instalment being quietly changed or contradicted in the next. In both cases, readers notice, and it erodes their trust in the world's stakes. *Serpent & Dove* illustrates how even a simple, consistent rule can do a lot of work. The magic system runs on equivalent exchange: every spell costs something of equal value to the outcome. While it's not a complicated system, it stays consistent, and that consistency gives the magic real weight in every scene where Lou has to decide whether the cost is worth it. Creating a world that includes many details can be overwhelming to manage, particularly when creating a first draft of a full-length novel while you're still figuring out the details as you write. Use the Quick Reference sheets in this workbook. Write down how things work and check your document before writing scenes that involve those elements. It also helps to keep a running document of things you establish mid-draft. "In chapter 7, I established that the journey takes three days." Just like that. This keeps you from contradicting yourself three hundred pages later when you've forgotten what you wrote. If you need to bend a rule, add an in-world reason. Why *is* this journey faster? Why *doesn't* the magic work here? An explanation is far better than an inconsistency. And sometimes the best solution to "this rule is inconvenient" is not to break the rule but to let the inconvenience happen. Constraints create stories. Here's why this matters for the romance: when your world's rules can be bent at the whim of the author, readers stop trusting the obstacles keeping your couple apart. That forbidden relationship? Not so forbidden if there is no enforcement of the rule that prohibits it. That dangerous secret? Not so dangerous if consequences only occur when the plot calls for them. Consistency is what lends credibility to the romantic stakes, because the reader will believe that your world intends to follow through on its promises.

Power and Agency

These mistakes involve romantic dynamics where the worldbuilding itself does the work that the characters should be doing, through captivity, magical bonds, or fate.

Mistake #8: Captivity Romance Without Addressing Consent

One of the people involved has some sort of power over the other (prisoner, slave, guest of their captor, magically bound) and romance develops without the power imbalance being meaningfully addressed. The captive falls for the captor. The prisoner falls for the jailer. The dynamic is portrayed as romantic without addressing the captive's lack of ability to make a free choice. In fact, the ACOTAR series gives us both the error and the correction in its first two novels. The first book shows Feyre's relationship with Tamlin is based on "protection" which ends up being a form of imprisonment. Tamlin makes all of the choices for Feyre and limits her agency as he increases his control over her. At the time, this reads like a romance but the second novel totally reframes the situation. *ACOMAF* portrays Feyre's journey as a process of regaining her freedom of choice, and building a new romance with Rhysand based on equal choice and decision making and deliberately dismantling the power dynamic. This is why the series works *because* it dealt directly with the issue of the captivity dynamic, as opposed to leaving it unaddressed. Captivity type setups are so commonly used because they provide a means to create a strong sense of forced closeness and a strong sense of urgency. However, writers rarely consider the importance of consent in these situations and often use the fictional aspect of the writing to justify what would be problematic in real life. There will come a time when the captive is truly allowed to leave. The captive should know that they can leave at that time and *then* decide to remain. The type of romance that is based in captivity may be valid but that captivity must end before a true romance can begin. The characters should discuss the power imbalance. The captor needs to recognise that they have used their power to influence the captive's actions. The captive needs to deal with their conflicted emotions. Do not attempt to present the captivity as if it did not have an impact on the captive's emotions and reactions. If the captor wishes to have the captive's love they need to earn it. And they'll have to start by eliminating their power over the captive. A captor that keeps a captive prisoner while wanting them to love them is not romantic; they are a prison warden that wants credit for being kind to them. And be honest with yourself about the story you wish to tell. Captivity romance *can* be told well, but it is something you must intend to do. If you are unwilling to look into the ways of power, consent, and the complexities of developing feelings under duress, this may not be the correct scenario for your story.



Mistake #9: Fated Mates That Remove All Agency

The worldbuilding includes some form of magical destiny (fated mates, soul bonds, prophecy) and this destiny does all the romantic heavy lifting. Characters are together because they're fated to be, not because they chose each other. The magic creates the relationship; the characters are just along for the ride. The mate bond in ACOTAR is a useful example of how this can go sideways. The bond is presented as biological (designed to produce the strongest offspring) but it pairs different species, sometimes dangerously. Additionally, the mate bond appears to snap first for males, followed later by females. Readers have pointed out that the bond often does the romantic work that should be done by the characters themselves. *Twilight's* imprinting has a similar problem: once a werewolf imprints, there's no choice involved, and the relationship becomes a biological inevitability rather than something the characters build together. *The Cruel Prince* avoids this entirely. There's no magical bond, no fated connection. Jude and Cardan develop a relationship based on mutual distrust, political manoeuvring, and the development of a strong chemistry between them, which develops as a result of their *choice* to pursue each other against a myriad of reasons not to. The romance feels earned because no magic is doing the work for them. While fate and bonds provide a way for writers to create instant connections and guarantee a happy ending, when the magic does all the work, the characters do nothing, and readers don't feel the relationship is earned. The bond can bring them together, but the relationship should still require work. They should have disagreements, differing views, reasons they struggle to connect. Fate might say they're matched; that doesn't make them automatically compatible. If they had no trouble accepting the bond, there's no tension. Make acceptance require sacrifice, change, or loss. Give them reasons to fight it: past trauma, conflicting loyalties, personal goals that the bond threatens. The drama is in the resistance. And ask yourself this: if the bond didn't exist, would these two people have anything? Do they like each other? Do they have chemistry? Do they *see* each other? The bond should confirm a connection that's built on the page, not replace it. This is also where world rule consistency matters (see Mistake #7). If the rules of your bond change to meet the demands of the story, stronger when you need drama, weaker when you need conflict, readers will notice.

Pacing and Delivery

This mistake isn't about what you've built. It's about how you give it to the reader.



Mistake #10: The Worldbuilding Info Dump

You've created a richly detailed world and are so enthusiastic about your creation that you want to convey it all to the reader immediately. The early stages of your book resemble a lecture: the history of the kingdom, the rules of the magic system, the political factions, the cultural customs. Although your actual storyline has yet to begin, the reader already has "homework" to complete. Or maybe the info dump comes through dialogue, where two or more characters explain something to each other that both already know. Or through a protagonist who conveniently asks a lot of questions. Or through pages of internal monologue in which the character is reflecting on how the world works. Regardless of how you deliver the information dump, the result is the same: the pacing of the novel is slowed down, the characters lose their depth and instead become delivery systems for lore, and the romance (what the reader has come to read about) is put off until after you've explained enough of the world for the reader to follow along. Information dumping is often cited as one of the most frequent criticisms in romantasy reader reviews, and it hits some of the genre's biggest titles. *House of Earth and Blood* was heavily criticised for its first 100 pages because the sheer volume of factions, species, political structures, and terminology created a barrier to entry for many readers, and many describe the experience as "work" rather than "pleasure." While the worldbuilding is incredibly detailed, the relationship between Bryce and Hunt had a difficult time developing because many readers were too busy trying to process all of the information being presented to them to become emotionally invested. Many readers reported that the pace of the book did not pick up until well beyond the midpoint. *From Blood and Ash* took a different approach to presenting worldbuilding information, but it produced a similar problem for the reader. Poppy had been raised in isolation as the Maiden, and therefore she had plenty of reasons to ask a large number of questions, and those questions were primarily used as a way to present the worldbuilding, making what could have otherwise been tense scenes into Q&A sessions that delay the development of the romantic relationship between Poppy and Hawke. The idea that Poppy and Hawke are forbidden from being together is compelling, however it continues to get paused so the reader can gather more knowledge about the Ascended and the kingdom of Solis. *Kingdom of the Wicked* had the opposite problem: it withheld the majority of the worldbuilding information until the end of the series, and then dumped a massive amount of previously unknown lore into a rushed explanation near the end. Throughout the multiple novels in the series, the reader had no clear picture of the world's rules, and therefore the romantic stakes felt very vague, and then became overwhelming when everything was finally explained at the same time. It is usually due to the fact that the author does not believe the reader will be able to keep up with the details of the world without a complete brief prior to the start of the story. You've spent months building this world and you know exactly how everything ties together, so it feels essential that the reader understands it all before the story starts. But here's the thing: the reader will not want to understand the world if they don't care about the characters. They need to care about your characters before they'll *want* to understand your world.

FIX

What worldbuilding do you need at any given moment in your story? Only enough for the reader to understand what's happening in this scene and why it matters. That's it. They don't need the full history of the war in chapter one. Show them the scar on your protagonist's hand and the way she flinches when soldiers walk past. Save the rest until the reader is invested enough to want it. Anywhere possible, provide lore via action, not explanation. Rather than having your character explain how their magic system works, place them in a scene where they **have** to use it and show them what it costs. Rather than a paragraph explaining the various political factions, put your reader in a tense situation where loyalty to a faction puts them in harm's way. *The Cruel Prince* does this well; you learn about the fae court's rules through watching

Quick Self-Check

Before you finish your draft, run through this checklist:

- ☐ Can the romance happen ONLY in this world, or could it happen anywhere? (#1)
- ☐ Does the fantasy plot matter independently of the romance? Would removing the romance leave a functional story? (#2)
- ☐ Does your world feel real beyond the main characters, or does every element exist to serve the couple? (#3)
- ☐ If your world has modern attitudes, have you worldbuilt a reason for them? Do social rules create real consequences when broken? (#4)
- ☐ Does danger actually interrupt the romance, or does tension conveniently pause for relationship scenes? (#5)
- ☐ Do consequences that are threatened actually happen? Does *something* bad stick permanently? (#6)
- ☐ Have you ever broken your own rules for convenience? Could a beta reader catch a contradiction? (#7)
- ☐ If one character has power over the other, do they genuinely have the option to leave before choosing to stay? (#8)
- ☐ Could you explain why your characters choose each other without mentioning fate, bonds, or magic? (#9)
- ☐ Does your worldbuilding unfold through the story, or did you front-load it into the first few chapters? (#10)

If you answered “no” or “not sure” to any of these, go back and address it. These are the mistakes that separate forgettable romantasy from the books readers remember.

Final Thought: Mistakes Are Fixable

Writers will fall into some of these traps in early drafts. That’s normal. Identifying them isn’t failure; it’s part of the process. The goal isn’t to write perfectly the first time. It’s to develop the awareness to catch these patterns and the skills to fix them.

Since you’ve been thinking about these issues, you’re already ahead. Now take what you’ve learned and make your world stronger.